

The spadix tells you when. Everything else about this genus is contested — but the cue is the clearest in the family.

THE CYCLE

1	Female phase. The spadix goes wet and glistening , with a droplet at the tip of each flower. Early morning. This is the only signal that matters. Days 1–4, roughly.
2	Stigmas dry and brown. That band is finished. No amount of pollen will change it.
3	A gap of about a week. Nothing to do on this inflorescence. Line up the other half of the cross.
4	Male phase. Pollen appears on the surface — always after the fluid has gone. Can run to two weeks. Collect now.

WHAT YOU NEED

- Soft brush, or a clean finger
 - Paper envelope for pollen
 - Airtight tube and foil packet — see below
 - Loop-lock labels
- A second plant, or stored pollen
 - Organza bag, if the cross matters
 - Notebook — fruit can take two years

READING THE INFLORESCENCE

Spadix wet, glistening, droplets at each flower tip	Receptive. Pollinate now , and again tomorrow morning.
Stigmas dry, turning brown	That band is closed.
Pollen visible on the surface	Male phase. Its own stigmas are long past — collect, do not apply here.
Spathe or spadix changing colour	Some species shift hue at anthesis. If yours does, it is a free calendar.
Berries forming	Not proof. See the panel overleaf.



Wet and glistening
A droplet standing on **every flower**. This is the receptive state and the only signal that matters.



The same thing, closer
Stigmas visibly moist, four tepals around each. **No stamens showing** — that is how you know.



Male phase
Anthers out (1), shed pollen among droplets (2). Note the gradient up the spadix. **Collect now.**



Ripe
Berries pushed clear of the spadix, showing a flank that was hidden. The cue is the movement, not the colour.

Figures from the papers, cropped to fit. They are small because that is the resolution the sources embedded, and **scale bars may run off the frame** — do not read a measurement off one. Full versions, with sources named, are on the web page.

THE METHOD

- 01 Work two plants.** The phases do not overlap on one inflorescence, and a plant only ever has one open at a time. Collect pollen from a plant in male phase; use it on a different plant in female phase.
- 02 Wait for the wet spadix.** Early morning. Not the spathe — the spathe can look perfect for weeks while nothing is happening.
- 03 Smear the pollen up, down and around the whole spadix** with a brush or a finger. The flowers are in a gradient, not a state; you cannot see which band is ready.
- 04 Repeat on consecutive mornings**, as long as you have fluid and pollen. One application is a gamble.
- 05 Tag it immediately.** Parents, date, direction.

Anthurium breaks one rule that holds everywhere else in this family. Read the first panel before you trust a berry.

BERRIES ARE NOT PROOF

At least four *Anthurium* species set a full spadix of viable seed with no pollination at all — *Anthurium gracile*, *Anthurium scandens*, *Anthurium bakeri* and *Anthurium clarinervium*.

And selfing varies: bagged away from every insect, **nine species of twenty set seed anyway**, while seven other species set none.

So fruit tells you the plant is healthy, not that your cross took. If the parentage matters, bag the inflorescence and say so in your notes.

The seedlings are the only real test, and they are three years away.

STORING POLLEN — UNSETTLED, HONESTLY REPORTED

One figure exists: **“the pollen will not last more than a week or two”** — with no temperature and no sample size attached.

Growers disagree about the fridge. Some use airtight containers with or without desiccant; some report pollen moulding when refrigerated; one keeps it **on aluminium foil at room temperature** specifically to avoid that. **Try both on the same batch and record what happens.** Fresh pollen removes the question.

THE THREE NUMBERS

3–4 days	Droplets on the stigmas before the first anthers open, in the one species anyone timed.
3 months – 2 years	Pollination to ripe berry, depending on species. Find out which yours is.
~3 years	Seed to first flower — and the first blooms are often small and badly coloured. Do not cull on them.

WHEN IT FAILS

- 01 **The spadix was not wet.** Commonest cause by a distance.
- 02 **You only did it once.** Several mornings running.
- 03 **The pollen was dead.** See above.
- 04 **It worked and you are early.** Check your species' ripening time.
- 05 **The cross genuinely will not go.** Last, and rare: only three compatibility results exist for the whole genus.

SEED

Berries are ripe when they **pop out of the spadix**. One or two seeds each; the flesh is translucent and sweet, and the seed usually carries a **sticky appendage** — that is the plant working, not pulp you missed.

Sow immediately. Germination is one to three weeks, and the radicle is often already showing at harvest. Well-drained soilless mix; watch for damping off.

Photographs: Hartley, Krömer & Gibernau 2017; Etl, Francke, Schönenberger & Dötterl 2022 (CC BY 4.0); Bleiweiss et al. 2019; Hay & Cedeño-Fonseca 2019. Reproduced by permission; full versions and sources on the web page.

aroidpedia.com/anthurium-pollination